

CYCLE 5 & THE II-V-I

The Cycle of 5ths is the master progression grid — every ii-V-I relationship lives inside it. Any 3 consecutive nodes = a complete harmonic journey.

CYCLE 5 — SCALE DEGREES 1-4-7-3-6-2-5-1



Each arrow = down a Perfect 5th (or up a Perfect 4th). Any 3 consecutive nodes form a ii-V-I relationship. The cycle contains all 6 possible ii-V-I sequences in C major.

THE 6 II-V-I SEQUENCES EXTRACTED FROM CYCLE 5

#	II (SUBDOMINANT)	V (DOMINANT)	I (RESOLUTION)	TARGET
1	Dm7 ii	G7 V7	Cmaj7 I	The classic ii-V-I
2	Gm7	C7 V7/IV	Fmaj7	Resolves to IV
3	F#m7b5	B7 V7/iii	Em7	Resolves to iii
4	Bm7b5	E7 V7/vi	Am7	Resolves to vi (minor 251)
5	Em7	A7 V7/ii	Dm7	Resolves to ii
6	Am7	D7 V7/V	G7	Resolves to V

THE II-V-I VOICE LEADING DIAGRAM — THE TRITONE COLLAPSES INWARD



The tritone engine: G7's tritone is B (the major 3rd) and F (the b7). B rises by a half step to C (the root of Cmaj7). F falls by a half step to E (the major 3rd of Cmaj7). The tritone doesn't just create tension — it physically collapses inward by the smallest possible motion. This is why ii-V-I is so satisfying and inevitable.